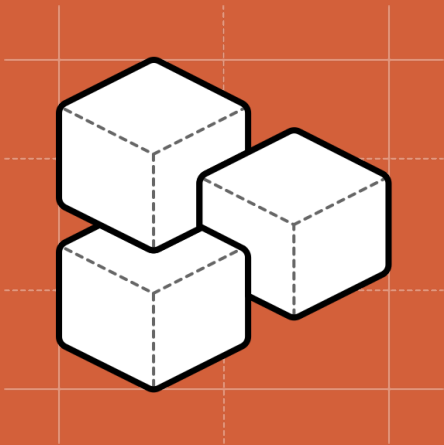


The Expansion Protocol

Turn mastery into more power, more seats, and your loudest advocates, with the agent leading the way.



What's inside:

- The Level Design model: why expansion is Level 3 of a game, and why your best users are the ones most likely to leave.
- How to tell when a user has outgrown their plan, so your product's AI offers more at the right moment instead of nagging everyone.
- The power-user game: how mastery turns into advocacy and more seats, with the agent inviting the right person by name.

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Where your best users outgrow you and leave

START HERE

Most products lose money at the bottom of the curve, the strangers who sign up and bounce. That's the leak everyone talks about. But there's a quieter one at the top, and it's the one that surprises teams, because it's their best people leaving. The user who learned the product cold, made it part of their week, told a coworker about it, and then one day stopped, because they'd squeezed everything out of it and you never gave them a bigger game to play.

I'm Bal. I've spent about twenty years across marketing and product in B2B SaaS, working with teams at companies like Google, Microsoft, and Intel. Titles changed over the years; the two disciplines didn't. For most of that time I was designing onboarding without calling it that. And the thing that took me longest to see is that the work doesn't stop at "can't work without this." There's a level past it, and most products never build it.

Here's the pattern. A user gets good, really good. They've hit the ceiling of their plan, they're doing three workarounds a week to get past limits you set, and they've started asking questions that are really requests for the next tier. That user is handing you the expansion on a plate. And most products answer with a billing-page popup, or nothing at all until the renewal email goes out. So the user either downgrades their enthusiasm to match the box you've kept them in, or they go find a product with more room. Either way you left money on the table, and lost the person most likely to have sold you to ten others.

That's what this protocol is about. Expansion is the third and last level of the game, and it has the best economics in all of software, because the user is already a believer. They don't need convincing, they need a bigger version of the thing they already love. It's where a subscription business compounds, and the level teams reach last.

One word on what I mean by the agent, because it runs through this whole protocol. The agent is the AI built into your product, the one that can talk to the user and actually do things for them, not a chatbot bolted on the side of an unchanged product. If you're building an agent-led product, that AI is already the main surface the user touches. If you're a more traditional product just now adding AI, it's the layer you're putting in. Either way the move is the same: that AI doubles as the onboarding. Expansion is where that pays off most, because the agent has watched this user the whole way up; it knows who's ready for more before they ask, and can offer it like a colleague, not a checkout page.

This protocol stands on its own; if it's the only one you read, you'll still get the whole model. The goal, in one line: build a level past mastery, so your best users grow into more power and bring others with them instead of quietly outgrowing you and leaving.



The model everything runs on

The game: Level Design for software

EXPANSION IS LEVEL 3 · MASTERY IS NOT THE EXIT · THE AGENT KNOWS WHO'S READY

Before the tactics, the model the whole stack runs on. If you only take one idea from this protocol, take this one.

Think of your product as a game, and your user as a player who starts as a stranger and, if things go right, becomes a power user who can't imagine working any other way. Getting them there isn't a phase; it's a series of levels they grow through. Think of a deep role-playing game, the kind people sink a hundred hours into, where each level hands the player a skill they'll need for the next, and new abilities open up as they master the old ones. Mastery is the destination, not the exit.

That game has three levels, and they're the three protocols in this stack:

- **Level 1, Activation.** The first real win. A stranger reaches a result that makes them think "okay, this works."
- **Level 2, Retention.** The win becomes a habit. They come back, get better, and the product opens up as they do.
- **Level 3, Expansion.** They hit the edges of what they've got, reach for more power, and start bringing other people in. This protocol.

What carries a player along is a loop: a **cue** that pulls them in, an **action** they take, and a **reward** that pays it off and sets up the next cue. In activation that loop fires once. In retention it runs until the win is a habit. In expansion the loop is still turning, but the reward changes shape: the payoff is no longer just the result they came for, it's more capability and reach. Expansion is what you unlock when the old loop has been mastered.

Here's the part that catches teams out. In a game, a player stays engaged while the challenge keeps pace with their skill. Software isn't a game; people use it to get work done, so the software version is about value, not fun: a product keeps a user as long as it keeps giving them more. The day a power user has wrung everything useful out of what you built, it stops compounding for them. They've plateaued, and a plateau is invisible, which is the hard truth underneath this level: your best users are the likeliest to leave, not because they're unhappy, but because they're the only ones who used up everything the product offers.

This is where agent-led software changes what's possible. A static product can't tell a master from a beginner; it shows everyone the same upgrade banner on the same schedule. The agent has watched this specific user the whole way up: what they've maxed out, what they keep working around, what they've taught themselves to do that the product doesn't support. It can see the edge they're pushing against and name the bigger game they're ready for, at the moment they're ready.

Everything that follows is how to design Level 3 so the agent can run it.

The whole protocol, one page

Read the rest for the why, or jump to the Expansion Protocol on page 18.

The game

- Expansion is Level 3: mastery turning into more power, more seats, and advocacy.
- Your best users are the ones most likely to leave, because they're the only ones who ran out of game.
- The agent watched the user all the way up, so it knows who's ready before they ask.

→ The reframe

- Upgrades feel salesy because they're discontinuous: a billing popup is a different voice arriving.
- Reframe the upsell as the next zone unlocking, from the same agent, at the moment of need. Earned, not sold.

The edge

- Expansion starts when a user pushes against a ceiling: usage maxing out, repeated workarounds, asking what the next tier does.
- Offer more only to the ready, not everyone, and judge fairly, with a path up.

The upgrade and the power-user game

- Lead with powers and unlocks, real new capability. A paywall ambush is a punishment.
- Build the power-user game: depth, teaching, governance, creation. Most products only build the one in the middle.
- Keep your best users by giving them somewhere to go next; the agent knows who they are.

Advocacy and the team

- Pride is what people share, and pride needs a surface: work that's visibly theirs, worth showing.
- Bring the team in as cooperation, not competition; in a B2B account the people who'd "lose" approve the renewal.



01

Expansion is the next zone, not a sales motion

THE UPGRADE ISN'T A PITCH. IT'S THE NEXT DOOR OPENING.

Most upgrade flows feel like a sales pitch because that's structurally what they are: a separate motion, in a different voice, interrupting the thing the user was actually doing. You're working, and a banner slides in from billing. The tone shifts, the avatar changes, the warmth you'd built up over months evaporates, and for a second the product stops being the tool you trust and becomes a company trying to charge you more. Even when the offer is fair, the seam is the problem. The user feels handed off from the product to the sales team, and nobody likes being sold to mid-task.

Compare that to how a game handles the same moment. In a deep role-playing game, you don't get a popup that says "upgrade to access the northern kingdom." You play, you get stronger, and one day you walk up to a gate that was closed before and it opens, because you're finally strong enough to be there. The bigger world was always the reward for mastering the smaller one. Nobody experiences that as a sales motion, even though, in business terms, it's the exact same thing: more game in exchange for more commitment. The difference is entirely in the framing. One is a door you earned. The other is a tollbooth that appeared.

That's the reframe, and it's the spine of this whole level. Expansion isn't a separate workstream that lives with sales or growth. It's the next zone of the same continuous experience, and it should be delivered by the same voice that got the user their first win and built their habit. When the upgrade comes from the companion the user already trusts, in the same tone, tied to something they were already trying to do, it stops reading as a pitch and starts reading as the product noticing they've outgrown their current room and offering them a bigger one.

The other half of the reframe is timing. A sales motion runs on the seller's calendar: end of quarter, renewal date, whenever the campaign goes out. The next-zone version runs on the user's readiness: the moment they hit the wall, not a date on your finance team's spreadsheet. Those are almost never the same moment, and the gap between them is why most upselling feels intrusive. You're being asked to buy more at a time that's convenient for the vendor and irrelevant to you. Move the offer to the moment of need and the intrusion disappears, because now it's an answer to a question you were actually asking.

This is the thing static products structurally cannot do, and it's why expansion has been done so badly for so long. A static product has no idea when any given user hits their wall, so it does the only thing it can: it shows everyone the same offer on the same schedule and accepts that most of them aren't ready. The agent has the missing information. It's been in the room the whole time. It can hold the upgrade until the user's own behavior says they're ready, then offer it in plain language, as the next thing rather than a transaction: "you've hit your page limit three times this week trying to track the checkout flow. I can open that up so you're not fighting the cap, want me to

walk you through it." That's not a pitch. That's the door opening at the moment the user arrived at it.

Stop running expansion as a separate sales motion bolted onto the side of the product, and start running it as the next zone of the same experience, delivered by the same agent, at the moment the user is ready instead of the moment your calendar says so.



Find the edge they're pushing against

OFFER MORE ONLY WHEN A USER HAS OUTGROWN WHAT THEY HAVE.

The whole reframe in chapter one depends on one thing: knowing when a specific user is ready. Offer the next zone too early and you're the same intrusive upsell you were trying to escape. Offer it at the right moment and it feels like a gift. So the core skill of expansion isn't persuasion, it's reading the edge: spotting the signal that a user has pushed up against the limits of what they've got and is reaching for more. Get good at reading the edge and most of the selling takes care of itself, because you're only ever offering more to people who already want it.

The edge shows up as behavior, not as a survey answer, and it's surprisingly legible once you know what to look for. Usage maxing out, the user bumping the ceiling of their plan again and again. Repeated workarounds, someone doing a clumsy three-step dance every week to get a result the next tier would hand them in one click. Reaching past the product, exporting data to do the real work somewhere else. And the loudest signal of all, the user literally asking: "is there a way to do X," where X is the headline feature of the tier above. Each of these is a person telling you, through what they do, that the room they're in has gotten too small.

Here's the discipline most teams miss: offer more only to the users who are ready, not the whole base. The temptation, once you have an upgrade to sell, is to put it in front of everyone, because more impressions must mean more upgrades. It's the opposite. A blanket offer trains your entire user base to treat your upgrade messaging as noise, including the people who would have said yes if you'd asked at the right time. Restraint is the strategy. The fewer people you show the offer to, and the better you time it, the more it converts and the less it costs you in goodwill. An offer that only ever appears when it's relevant becomes a signal users trust instead of an ad they tune out.

There's a deeper need underneath the well-timed offer, and it's worth naming because it changes the tone of the whole interaction. People want to be judged, as long as they're judged fairly. Think of a game that scores your run and then shows you exactly what to do better next time; players don't resent that, they replay to beat it, because the judgment is honest and it comes with a path up. The gentle life-simulation game *Animal Crossing* has an in-game academy that quietly rates the house you've decorated and tells you how to improve it, and players will redecorate for days chasing a better grade from an imaginary committee. The grade motivates because it's fair and because there's a clear way to climb. An upgrade offer, done right, is the same shape: a fair read of where the user is, with a concrete path to the next level.

This is the move that simply was not possible before agent-led products, and it's the heart of why expansion is finally solvable. Reading the edge per user, across thousands of users, in real time, is not something a static product or a quarterly campaign can do. The agent can. It has the usage history, it can see the workarounds and the repeated bumps against the ceiling, and it can

recognize the pattern for one specific person and act on it the moment it appears. It can also deliver the fair judgment in the user's own terms: "you've basically outgrown the single-project setup, you're managing four in your head right now. Want me to show you what the multi-project view would do for you?"

Expansion starts with reading the edge, not with crafting a pitch. Watch for the user pushing against a ceiling, offer more only to the ones who are ready, and frame the offer as a fair read of where they are with a clear path up.



03

Power up, never pressure

AN UPGRADE IS A POWER-UP, NOT A PAYWALL.

Once you know who's ready, the question is what the upgrade actually feels like when it arrives. This is where most products quietly turn a believer into a resentful customer, because they treat the upgrade as a wall to be paid through rather than a power to be earned. The same transaction can be either one. The money changing hands is identical; the feeling is opposite, and the feeling is what determines whether the user upgrades gladly or upgrades grudgingly and starts shopping around.

Games are precise about this, and the lesson is worth stealing exactly. The rewards that actually keep a player going aren't the flashy ones; spectacle wears off fast, and by the fifth celebration the confetti is wallpaper. The rewards that last are the ones that change what the player can do: a new ability, a gate that lifts, a power that wasn't there before. An upgrade should be one of those.

"You've earned enough range with the basic version that I can now hand you the advanced controls" is a power-up. The user worked their way to it, and crossing the line gives them genuinely more to do. That's a reward people move toward on their own, because it's real and it compounds.

The paywall ambush is the same line drawn as a punishment, and you've felt it. You're mid-task, you reach for the obvious next step, and a wall slams down: this feature is locked, upgrade to continue. Nothing about your situation changed except that the product just penalized you for trying to use it. That's a punishment a user couldn't predict or prevent, which is the exact kind that makes someone disengage entirely, because it feels like a trap was set. The fix isn't to give the feature away. It's to flip the framing from a stick to a carrot: instead of blocking the action and demanding payment, show the upside and let the user reach for it. "This works on one project today. On the team plan I'd run it across all of them at once, here's what that looks like." Same gate, same price, but now it's a power on offer instead of a door slammed in your face.

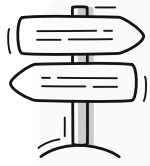
There's a particular reward worth building into the top of your product: a bolder path sitting next to the safe one. Alongside the standard way of working, offer a riskier, more powerful way that a confident user can choose. In a lot of games the most engaging option is the optional hard one, the path that's tougher and pays off bigger, and the freedom to take it is itself a reward, because choosing it is how a skilled player proves they've leveled up. In your product it looks like "I can keep this on the simple setup, or, more ambitious, I can wire it straight into your other tools and automate the whole chain, which way do you want to go." The bold option is an upgrade the user opts into rather than gets sold, and the act of choosing it makes them feel like a power user.

One honest caution, because the dark version of all this is everywhere and it's tempting. The most predatory monetization in games right now is the loot box, the randomized paid prize where you pay for a chance at something good and the unpredictability is engineered to keep you paying. It

works on people, which is precisely why it's the wrong move in a tool people trust with their business. Anything that uses artificial scarcity, manufactured urgency, or a manipulated sense of chance to push an upgrade is borrowing from the casino, and a B2B user will eventually notice and resent it. Borrow the structure that makes upgrades feel good, earned power, real new capability, a bold path for the ready. Skip the manipulation.

The agent is what lets you do the generous version at scale, because it can frame every upgrade moment as a power-up in the user's own terms, live, instead of you hard-coding a wall. It fixes or works around what it can, and where it genuinely hits a tier limit, it names the upside rather than the block: "I've taken this as far as the current plan goes; the next tier would let me run this automatically every morning, want me to set that up." That's the same boundary a paywall would have enforced, delivered as an open door instead of a closed one.

Make every upgrade a power-up the user earns and chooses, not a paywall that ambushes them mid-task. Lead with real new capability, offer a bold path for the ready, skip every casino trick, and let the agent frame each limit as a door opening.



04

Build the power-user game

GIVE YOUR BEST USERS SOMEWHERE TO GO NEXT.

Here's the structural mistake almost every product makes: it builds exactly one experience, the one for the competent regular, and nothing on either side of it. There's a rough on-ramp for the newcomer and a flat nothing for the user who's mastered the thing. The newcomer problem is what activation solves. The power-user problem is what expansion solves, and it's the one nobody designs for, because a power user looks like a success right up until the day they leave. A user who has mastered everything you built and finds nothing past it has stopped getting more out of the product, and a power user who's stopped getting more is one who quietly stops expanding, and eventually goes looking for a tool with more room in it.

The clearest way to see the fix comes from a story game designers tell about a neighborhood Easter egg hunt. The little kids hunt for eggs in an easy zone where they're sure to find some. The middle kids hunt properly, across the whole yard. And the oldest kids, who'd get nothing out of just hunting, get a different job entirely: they hide the eggs and give the little ones hints. Three ages, one event, everyone fully engaged, because each level of skill got its own version of the game. The point that ports to software is the structure: your best users don't need a harder version of the same thing, they need a different one. Call it the power-user game, the level you build for the people who've finished the regular one.

So the work of this chapter is to design that level, the one a user reaches after they've mastered the rest. It has a few shapes, and most products can build at least one. There's depth: advanced capability, real power tools, the ability to do things the standard version never exposed. There's teaching: letting an expert show others how, answer questions, write the playbook for your product that you couldn't write as well yourself. There's governance: giving trusted power users a hand in how the product works for their team, setting the standards, curating what others see. And there's creation: letting a master build something on top of your product, a template, a workflow, a configuration, that other users actually adopt. Any one of these gives a power user somewhere to go next. The absence of all of them is why your best users quietly leave.

The build-anything sandbox game Minecraft is the cleanest example of this done right, and it's worth seeing why. Once a player has mastered survival, the game is "over" in any conventional sense, and that's exactly when the most committed players go deeper, not away. They build elaborate worlds, they run servers other people play on, they make tutorials that teach newcomers. The game gave its best players depth, creation, teaching, and governance, and in return those players became the thing that keeps the whole world alive. None of that is a separate marketing program. It's a level designed on purpose, for the people who finished the others.

This is where your product's AI does something no product could do before, and it's the quiet engine of the whole chapter. To run a power-user game you first have to know who your power users actually are, and a static product genuinely doesn't; it can't tell a true master from someone who just has an old account. The agent watched everyone level. It knows exactly who's reached the ceiling of what the product currently offers, because it was there for every step. And it can invite that specific person into the power-user game by name, the moment they've earned it: "you've built the most thorough setup I've seen in this account. Want me to package it as a template the rest of the team can use, with your name on it?" That invitation, personal, earned, timed, is how a power user gets pulled into a bigger version of the product instead of plateauing and drifting out.

Most products build one experience and lose their best users when those users run out of room to grow. Build the power-user game too, depth, teaching, governance, creation, and let the agent invite your power users into it by name, the moment they've earned the invitation.



When users sell for you

PRIDE IS WHAT PEOPLE SHARE. GIVE IT A SURFACE.

Advocacy is the biggest payoff of the power-user game, and it's almost always misunderstood as a marketing problem. Teams stand up a referral program, offer a credit for a testimonial, run a campaign to manufacture word of mouth, and get a trickle. Real advocacy isn't a program you bolt on; it's a byproduct of users who've gone far enough to be proud of what they did with your product. You don't generate it with incentives. You earn it by building a level worth mastering, and then you give that pride somewhere to show.

Because that's the mechanism, and it's worth being precise about it: people share what they're proud of. Not what you ask them to share, not what earns them a ten-dollar credit; what makes them look good to people whose opinion they care about. Which means the question isn't "how do we get users to refer us," it's "what have our users built that they'd be proud to show off, and are we giving them a surface to show it on." Pride needs a surface. Something the user made, visibly theirs, worth putting in front of a colleague or a peer. No surface, no sharing, no matter how good the underlying work was.

Games understand this completely. Look at Super Mario Maker, where the entire game is players building their own levels for other people to play, with the maker's name attached to every one. People pour hours into a level not because the game asked them to, but because it's theirs, it's clever, and someone else is going to play it and know they made it. The pride and the surface are the whole design. The maker's name on the level is the point. Your product can do the same thing: a workflow, a template, a configuration, a result, built by a user, credited to them, visible to others. The moment a user's work carries their name and gets seen, you've turned a private mastery into a public one, and public mastery is what people share.

The story that actually travels, the one worth engineering everything toward, is "this product changed how I work." Not "this product has good features," not "this product is fast." The transformation story. A user who can say their week looks different now, that something that used to take an hour takes a sentence, that they're good at something they weren't good at before, has a story they'll tell unprompted, because it's really a story about them getting better, and people love telling that one. Features don't travel. Transformation does. The deepest measure of whether your product earned an advocate isn't usage, it's whether the user changed, and whether they know it.

The agent is what makes that story visible to the user, which is what makes it shareable, and this is its sharpest move in the whole expansion level. A transformation that happens gradually is invisible to the person living it; they don't notice the slope, they just slowly get better. The agent saw the whole slope. It can narrate the change back to the user in a single line drawn from their own history: "three weeks ago this report took you an hour and a back-and-forth with your analyst. Today you

asked me one question." That sentence does three jobs at once. It's the reward that deepens retention, it's the honest case for the upgrade, and it's the exact story the user will retell to a peer, handed to them ready to share. And the agent can do the last step too, inviting the share by name at the moment of pride.

Advocacy isn't a referral program, it's the power-user game producing users proud of what they built. Give that pride a surface, work that's visibly theirs and worth showing, engineer toward the "it changed how I work" story, and let the agent narrate the transformation and invite the share.



Bring the team in

GROW FROM ONE POWER USER TO THE WHOLE TEAM.

The last move in expansion is the jump from one user to many: the single power user becomes a team, the one seat becomes ten. In a B2B product this is usually where the real money is, because a beloved tool spreading across an account is worth more than any single user upgrading their own plan. But it's also where teams reach for the wrong playbook, importing tactics from consumer games that actively backfire inside a company, so it's worth being careful about which game mechanics travel to multiplayer and which ones blow up.

Start with the one that blows up: competition. Leaderboards, head-to-head rankings, "you're in the bottom 20% of your team" nudges. These are powerful in consumer games and toxic across a B2B account, for a structural reason that's easy to miss. In a company, the people who would "lose" your competition are the people who approve the renewal. Embarrass a manager by ranking their team low, or pit colleagues against each other, and you've made an enemy exactly where you needed a champion. The person at the bottom of your leaderboard might be the budget holder. Competition assumes losing is harmless fun; inside an account, losing has a boss, and that boss signs the check.

What does travel is cooperation. Co-op games, the ones where a group succeeds or fails together, are the right model for multiplayer expansion. Think of a cooperative cooking game like *Overcooked*, where everyone in the kitchen wins or loses as one and the whole point is coordinating well together; nobody's trying to beat their teammate, they're trying to beat the level as a unit. That's the feeling you want when a tool spreads across a team: shared progress, shared wins, the group getting better together. Design the multi-user experience so that bringing a colleague in makes both people's experience better, not so that it ranks them against each other. Shared workspaces, visible team progress toward a common goal, the satisfaction of a group hitting something together. Cooperation makes the renewal easy because everyone associates the product with winning as a team.

The move itself, expanding from one seat to the team, should feel like the next zone unlocking, the same as every other upgrade in this protocol, not like a sales rep showing up to talk about seat licenses. The natural on-ramp is the work the power user already did. The user who built the great template or the clean workflow has made something the rest of the team would benefit from, and "share this with your team" is a smaller, more natural ask than "buy nine more seats." The seats follow the sharing. You don't sell the team plan; you make the power user's mastery useful to the people around them, and the team plan becomes the obvious way to do that. The expansion rides in on the advocacy from the last chapter.

This is, again, the agent's moment, because the multi-user jump depends on knowing things only the agent knows. It knows who the power user is, it knows what they built that's worth sharing, and

it can see when an account has one person carrying a tool that three more people are quietly leaning on through that one person. It can make the move feel like a natural next step rather than a sales motion: "you're the only one in your company set up on this, but I can see two others using your exports secondhand. Want me to get them their own setup so you're not the bottleneck?" That's the seat expansion framed as a favor to the user, solving a real friction in their day, with the revenue following the help.

The team expansion is the next zone, not a seat-license pitch. Skip competition, because in a B2B account the losers approve the renewal; build for cooperation, where the team wins together; let the power user's shared work pull the seats in behind it, and let the agent make the multi-user move feel like getting the team unblocked.



The worksheet

The Expansion Protocol

DO IT YOURSELF, OR HAND IT TO YOUR FAVORITE LLM

Work through it for your product, or hand it to your favorite LLM along with this protocol and your product details and have it draft each answer with you, then sharpen. Either way you finish with a defined edge signal, an upgrade that feels like a power-up, a power-user game your best users can play, and an agent that invites the right person at the right moment.

STEP 1: REFRAME THE UPGRADE AS THE NEXT ZONE

Write the upgrade moment as a door opening, in the agent's voice, not a billing popup.

When the user reaches _____ (the moment of need),
the agent offers _____ (the next zone) as the natural next step.

STEP 2: DEFINE THE EDGE SIGNALS

The behaviors that say a user is ready for more. Be specific; these are what the agent watches for.

EDGE SIGNAL

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN YOUR PRODUCT

Usage maxing out

Repeated workarounds

Asking for the next tier

STEP 3: TURN THE PAYWALL INTO A POWER-UP

List the gates where your product asks for an upgrade today. For each, write the carrot version.

THE PAYWALL (TODAY)

THE POWER-UP (RESTATED)

The bold path a ready user can opt into (riskier, more powerful, their choice):

STEP 4: BUILD THE POWER-USER GAME

What does a user do after they've mastered your product? Fill in at least one; more is better.

POWER-USER PATH

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE FOR YOUR PRODUCT

Depth (advanced power)

Teaching (expert helps others)

Governance (shapes it for the team)

Creation (builds something others use)

STEP 5: GIVE PRIDE A SURFACE

The work a user could build that they'd be proud to show:

Where it becomes visibly theirs, with their name on it:

The "it changed how I work" story the agent can narrate from their usage:

STEP 6: MAKE THE MULTIPLAYER MOVE COOPERATIVE

The power user's shared work that pulls the team in:

The cooperative payoff (how bringing a colleague in makes both better):

The agent's line that frames more seats as getting the team unblocked:

All six filled in is your Level 3 design: an upgrade reframed as the next zone, edge signals the agent can read, paywalls turned into power-ups, a power-user game for your best users, a surface for pride, and a cooperative path to the whole team. That's expansion. And it's the last level of the game.



The dual use

Run this with your favorite LLM

THE PROTOCOL IS THE EXPERT; YOUR AI ASSISTANT DOES THE LOCALIZING

You can read this protocol and do the work yourself. The faster move, and the one it's built for, is to hand the whole thing to your favorite LLM and design your expansion with you. Attach this protocol, give it a few paragraphs about your product (what it is, who it's for, what your power users and your paid tiers look like today), then work through these asks in order.

ASK YOUR LLM	WHAT YOU'RE GETTING	CH.
"Rewrite my current upgrade moment as the next zone unlocking, in the voice of my product's agent, instead of a billing pitch."	The upsell reframed as a door opening, in one continuous voice.	01
"What are the specific edge signals that say a user is ready for more, and how would the agent spot each one?"	The behaviors the agent watches for, so you pitch the ready, not everyone.	02
"Go through my paywalls and restate each one as a power-up, then design a bold path a ready user can opt into."	Upgrades that feel earned instead of ambushing, plus a bold tier.	03
"Design the power-user game for my product across depth, teaching, governance, and creation, and tell me which to build first."	A level past mastery so my best users keep getting value instead of plateauing.	04
"What could my users build that they'd be proud to show, and what's the 'it changed how I work' story the agent can narrate?"	A surface for pride and the transformation story that drives advocacy.	05
"Design the move from one user to the team as cooperation not competition, and write the agent's line that frames more seats as getting the team unblocked."	A multiplayer expansion that makes the renewal easy.	06

Push back on your AI assistant the way you would on a teammate. If an upgrade reads like a paywall instead of a power-up, say so and make it try again. The model gives you the structure and the judgment; your taste decides what's actually right for your users. That last bit is the part that's yours.

Three levels, one game, one agent. Get a stranger to their first win, turn the win into a habit, then turn mastery into more power and an advocate, without ever handing the user off.

The Onboarding Loop Protocols

BAL SIEBER · EXPANSION, LEVEL 03